

A FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

ROOM 36

The Year of Two Voices

BOOK THREE OF THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

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CHAPTER ONE

The Mask & the Mirror



Amara has been at Lincoln Park Middle School for one year.

The cohort moved up together at the end of fifth grade — a new building, new teachers, new kids from two other elementary schools folded in. The cohort had walked in last August as a known unit, nine kids who already knew each other's names with the right vowels.

By the end of sixth grade, Amara had made friends, of a kind, with two girls from the other elementary schools. Brielle and Cassidy. The kind of friends you would call friends but who you would not, in any precise sense, call cohort. They sat with Amara at lunch sometimes. They had her over for one birthday party. They had been, more or less, the adjacent people in Amara's life all year.

Adjacent.

That was the word Amara had been finding for it, this past summer, in her journal.

Adjacent was the word for the version of herself she had been around Brielle and Cassidy — the slightly modified Amara who agreed with Brielle's opinions about the seventh-grade boys, who pretended to know the songs Cassidy played in the car, who laughed at jokes she did not really think were funny because the laughing was easier than not-laughing. Adjacent was the word for the Amara who, when somebody at Brielle's house had said something a little mean about a girl named Hannah in the year above them, had not said anything.

Now she had the word. The word was uncomfortable.

The word was uncomfortable because Amara had spent six years with the cohort being not adjacent. The cohort had been the room where Amara was Amara. Three syllables. The soft *a* at the end, the way her grandmother said it on Sunday afternoons. The version of herself that designed the bench-sign in third grade. The version that, in fifth grade, had been the kid the cohort knew would notice when somebody was missing from the lunch table.

That Amara had not gone away in sixth grade. That Amara was still there. The cohort still got that Amara every day at lunch.

But Brielle and Cassidy got adjacent Amara. And adjacent Amara had been, gradually across sixth grade, taking up more of the day than cohort Amara. Most days had more Brielle-and-Cassidy hours in them than cohort hours, because the cohort was scattered across different sections of different classes and the only fully cohort time was lunch.

By the end of sixth grade, Amara had — and she wrote this in her journal, in pencil, in July — *lost track of which Amara was the real one*.

She had stared at that sentence in her journal for a long time. She had put the journal under her mattress, not because anyone in her house would read it, but because she did not want to read it again herself.

This is what nobody tells you about the Mask.

The Mask is not always lying.

The Mask is sometimes just being a kid in a new room with new people and reading the room and adapting to it. That is not a moral failure. That is how human beings have survived since we lived in caves. *Read the room. Adapt. Do not get eaten.*

The problem is not the Mask. The problem is when the Mask becomes so habitual that you lose contact with what is underneath — when every choice gets routed through *what will keep me safe in this room* before it touches *what is actually true about me*. The problem is when the Mirror gets so dusty you cannot see yourself in it anymore.

Amara, on the first day of seventh grade, was about to figure out that this was going to be the year of the Mirror.

She did not know that yet on the morning of the first day. She was, on the morning of the first day, just trying to find Room 36.

Room 36 was on the second floor of the middle school, in the corner of the seventh-grade hallway. The Mistake Wall, over the summer, had been moved from sixth-grade hallway to seventh — Ms. Calloway had done it the second week of August, by herself, in the afternoons, while the building was still mostly empty.

The Wall, when Amara walked past it that morning, had eight cards on it already. Seven of them she recognized from last year, in different cohort kids' handwriting. The eighth was new — a card by somebody she did not know. The card said *I forgot to feed my hamster for three days*. The card was unsigned. It had been, Amara guessed, written by one of the sixth-graders who was now a seventh-grader, who had walked past the Wall on their orientation visit last week and had wanted to start the year right.

Amara stopped at the Wall for a second. She did not write a card. She did not need to. She just looked.

The Wall was the cohort's most public artifact. The cohort had inherited it and carried it. The cohort had also — and Amara knew this without anyone saying it — protected it. Last year a seventh-grader had taken a card off the Wall as a joke and the cohort had, collectively and without any organizing meeting, gotten the card back and put it back up within thirty-six hours. The Wall did not, in their building, get messed with.

She walked into Room 36. Mr. Patel was at the front.

She had not been in a classroom with Mr. Patel since fifth grade, when he had been the cohort's main teacher for a year. He had then moved up to seventh grade. The cohort had not seen him much in sixth grade — they had been in different classrooms, with different teachers. Now, on the first day of seventh grade, here he was again.

Mr. Patel had aged a little. He had a small gray streak in the front of his hair that had not been there in fifth grade. He was wearing a button-down shirt with the sleeves rolled up — same as fifth grade. He had the same coffee mug on his desk, a gift from a previous cohort, with a picture of a small cartoon owl wearing glasses.

He looked up. He saw the first cohort kids walking in. Theo came in just before Amara. Marcus came in just after. Priya was already at her desk, having gotten to school early because Priya was Priya.

Mr. Patel said, *Marcus. Theo. Priya. Amara. You four. And — let me see — Maya and Jordan in second period, Sofia and Darius in fourth, Kezia in fifth. The schedule got you scattered. I have all of you across the day.*

Theo said, *Mr. Patel. You memorized our schedules?*

Mr. Patel said, *Theo. I have been thinking about this cohort all summer. Of course I memorized the schedules.*

Marcus said, *Mr. Patel. Welcome back.* Mr. Patel said, *Marcus. Thank you. I have missed you all. Take your seats.*

Amara took a seat. She looked around.

The room had the U-shape desks Mr. Patel always used. Twenty-three students. Most of them she recognized from the grade. A few were faces she only sort of knew. The cohort, in this first period, was four of them — Marcus, Theo, Priya, Amara. Five of the other nineteen kids were going to be people the cohort would have to figure out how to be in a room with, daily, for nine months.

One of them was a girl Amara did not really know, sitting two seats down, with her phone out under the desk. Amara recognized the girl's face but did not know her name. The girl had been in Amara's sixth-grade math class. The girl had not, all of last year, said two words to Amara.

The girl, this morning, looked up from her phone and made eye contact with Amara. She gave Amara a small smile. Amara smiled back.

The girl said, very quietly, *did you do the summer reading?* Amara said, *yes. Was it bad?* — *No, actually. It was — it was good.* — *Thank god. Cassidy said it was bad. I trusted her.*

Amara's stomach did a small thing.

She had not seen Brielle or Cassidy yet today. She did not know what section they were in. She did not, exactly, know how she was going to be around them today, or this week, or this year.

The girl said, *I'm Maddie, by the way.* — *I'm Amara.* — *I know. I had you in math last year. You were the kid who sat in the third row and never said anything.*

Amara said — and this came out before she could stop it — *that was the sixth-grade version of me.*

Maddie laughed. *What's the seventh-grade version going to be?* — *I am — I am still figuring it out.* — *Cool. Tell me when you know.*

Mr. Patel cleared his throat at the front of the room. The class settled.

Mr. Patel said, *good morning. I am Mr. Patel. Most of you know me. Some of you do not. I will introduce myself properly in a minute. First, though, I want to do something a little different.*

He picked up a marker. He walked to the board. He wrote, in his familiar handwriting:

WHO ARE YOU GOING TO BE THIS YEAR?

He turned around.

That is not a question I want you to answer out loud. I want you to take five minutes. I want you to sit with it. I want you to write down — for yourself, in your notebook, no one else is going to read it — one sentence that answers it. Or a starting attempt at answering it. Or a question about the question. Or a drawing, if you are Maya, who is not in this section but who I will see in second period and who I already know is going to draw rather than write.

Marcus laughed. Mr. Patel said, *five minutes. Start.* The class wrote.

Amara opened her notebook. She thought, for a second, about *adjacent*. She thought about Maddie's question. *What's the seventh-grade version going to be?*

She wrote:

The seventh-grade version of me is going to be Amara. Three syllables. The cohort version. Not the adjacent version. I am going to try, this year, to make adjacent smaller and Amara bigger, in every room I am in. I am going to make the Mirror less dusty.

She read it. She felt a small steadying. The sentence was not, in any sense, true yet. The sentence was a commitment. The sentence was what Mr. Patel had asked for. A starting attempt at an answer.

She closed the notebook. She looked up.

Maddie, two seats down, had also closed her notebook. Maddie was looking at her phone again. Maddie made eye contact with Amara for a second and gave the small *I am also writing things I do not understand* shrug. Amara nodded back.

Mr. Patel said, *good. Most of you have written something. Some of you have written nothing. Both are fine. We are going to come back to that sentence many times this year. I want you to know — this is the year we figure out who you are when no one is watching. That is the work. That is what Room 36 is for.*

He paused. *Welcome.*

The class said, in various volumes, *thank you, Mr. Patel.*

The year began.

END OF THE FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

This is the year we figure out who you are when no one is watching.

Room 36 — The Year of Two Voices

Book Three of the five-book companion series to *The Architecture of Grace*